

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Leader — First 30 Days Checklist

A structured onboarding plan for your first month leading a quality function — listen first, diagnose, then commit.

Purpose

The first thirty days set the tone for how you will be trusted for the next thirty months. This checklist keeps you disciplined during a period when it is tempting to arrive with a fixed plan and start "fixing things". Its purpose is the opposite: to help you listen, gather evidence, understand the delivery context and build relationships before you commit to a direction. By the end of the month you should be able to describe the current state honestly, name the top few risks, and propose an initial direction that the people around you recognise as fair.

It is deliberately weighted towards understanding over action. A QA leader who spends week one restructuring the team has usually optimised for looking decisive rather than being right.

When to use it

- You have just joined an organisation as its Head of QA, QA Manager, QA Lead or Test Manager.
- You have been promoted into a quality-leadership role over a team you were previously part of (adapt the "build relationships" items — you already have some of this).
- You have inherited a quality function after a reorganisation, an acquisition or a departing leader.
- You are a consultant engaged to review and improve a testing capability, and need a defensible first-month structure.

Instructions

Work through the four weekly blocks below. Treat each unchecked item as an open question, not a task to rush. Keep a private running document of what you learn — quotes, numbers, contradictions — because your credibility later rests on being able to show you understood before you acted. Aim to end the month with three deliverables: a written current-state summary, a shortlist of the top risks, and a lightweight 90-day direction you have socialised with your manager and your team.

- Do not commit to major structural or tooling changes in month one. Note them; decide later.
- Meet people one-to-one before forming views from documents alone. Documents lie by omission.
- Separate what you are told from what you observe. Where they differ, that gap is itself a finding.
- Protect the team from your own eagerness — an early wrong call is expensive to walk back.

Worked example

Below is the checklist as a newly appointed Head of QA might have completed it at Northstar Digital, a mid-sized Series B digital-products company with six QA engineers supporting around thirty-five developers across four squads.

Week	Item	Done?	What was learned at Northstar
1 — Listen	One-to-one with your manager (VP Engineering) — clarify the mandate and how success is judged	Yes	Priya wants risk and delivery outcomes, not test-case counts. Success = faster releases without more incidents.
1 — Listen	One-to-one with every member of your team	Yes	Sofia is a strong exploratory tester and informal lead, wary after a failed "automate everything" push. Dan owns a flaky Selenium suite and is quietly burning out.
1 — Listen	Understand the products, architecture and customers	Yes	React web app, React Native mobile, public + internal REST APIs, payments via a third party plus a legacy in-house billing monolith.
2 — Observe	Sit in on a release and a regression pass end to end	Yes	A ~5-day manual regression precedes major releases; QA is pulled in late, once stories are code-complete.
2 — Observe	Review the last few months of production defects and incidents	Yes	Escaped defects trending up; severity/priority used loosely in Jira; little data on customer impact.
2 — Observe	Map the current metrics — what is measured and reported today	Yes	Test-case counts and bugs-found are reported; nothing on escaped defects or change failure rate.
3 — Diagnose	Meet key stakeholders outside QA (Product, a sceptical squad lead)	Yes	Tom (Product) pushes hard on dates but is reasonable when shown residual risk. Marcus (Payments) is unconvinced QA adds value — not hostile, just unconvinced.
3 — Diagnose	Assess environments, test data and CI	Yes	Shared staging is unstable with unreliable data; CI runs build + unit tests on PR; releases are human-approved.
3 — Diagnose	Identify quick, low-risk wins that build trust	Yes	Tighten Jira severity/priority definitions; add a short shared smoke test before regression begins.
4 — Commit	Write a one-page current-state summary	Yes	Circulated to Priya and the team; no surprises — a sign the listening worked.
4 — Commit	Name the top 3 risks and an initial 90-day direction	Yes	Late QA involvement, low trust in automation, and no shared definition of done / quality gate.
4 — Commit	Agree how you and your manager will stay aligned	Yes	Fortnightly 30-minute check-in framed around risk and delivery, not activity.

Blank reusable version

Week	Item	Done?	Notes / evidence
1 — Listen	One-to-one with your manager — clarify mandate and how success is judged		
1 — Listen	One-to-one with every member of your team		

Week	Item	Done?	Notes / evidence
1 — Listen	Understand the products, architecture and customers		
1 — Listen	Read existing test strategy / plans / process docs (note what is missing)		
2 — Observe	Sit in on a release and a regression / test pass end to end		
2 — Observe	Review recent production defects and incidents		
2 — Observe	Map the current metrics — what is measured and reported today		
2 — Observe	Observe how requirements arrive and how "done" is defined		
3 — Diagnose	Meet key stakeholders outside QA (Product, Engineering, Support)		
3 — Diagnose	Assess environments, test data and CI/CD		
3 — Diagnose	Assess team skills, morale and workload		
3 — Diagnose	Identify quick, low-risk wins that build trust		
4 — Commit	Write a one-page current-state summary		
4 — Commit	Name the top 3 risks and an initial 90-day direction		
4 — Commit	Socialise the direction with your team and your manager		
4 — Commit	Agree a regular alignment cadence with your manager		

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Arriving with a pre-baked plan from your last job and applying it before you understand this context. Reorganising the team in week one. Announcing an "automation strategy" before you know why the current automation is distrusted. Talking more than you listen in one-to-ones. Confusing being busy with making progress — a month of visible activity that skips diagnosis usually produces a confident plan aimed at the wrong problem.

How to interpret the results

Read the completed checklist as a picture of where you are, not a score.

- Mostly complete with consistent findings — you have a solid evidence base. Proceed to a current-state assessment and a 90-day plan with confidence.
- Complete, but your team and your stakeholders describe different realities — the gap is your most valuable finding. Investigate it before planning; it often reveals where trust has broken down.
- Items still open at day 30 — do not paper over them. Name the gaps explicitly in your summary and say how you will close them, rather than inventing conclusions you have not earned.

- Everything looks fine and you found no risks — treat this as a red flag, not reassurance. Either you have not looked hard enough, or you are being managed. Dig into the defect and incident data again.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Your first 30 days buy you a one-time credibility budget. Spend it on understanding, not on announcements. The leader who can say "here is what I found, here is the evidence, and here is where I think we should focus" earns far more trust than the one who arrives with answers to questions nobody asked.